ERA 20

The Movement Begins

1954 – 1963

Brown · Little Rock · Montgomery · nonviolent protest

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did African Americans challenge segregation—and force the nation to confront it?

KEY TERMS

Brown v. Board · Little Rock · the Montgomery Bus Boycott · sit-ins · Birmingham

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 8.6, 8.10 · AMSCO Ch. 8.6, 8.10

CHALLENGING JIM CROW

The Struggle Renewed

Brown v. Board of Education



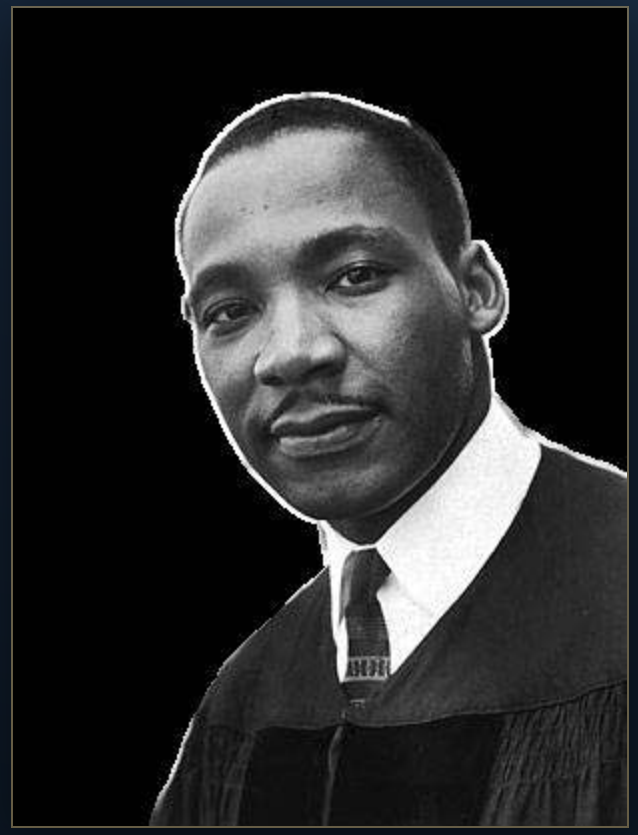
- In 1954, the **Warren Court** unanimously struck down school segregation.
- **Brown v. Board of Education** overturned '**separate but equal**.'
- The ruling declared segregated schools 'inherently unequal.'

Massive Resistance & Little Rock

- The white South met integration with '**massive resistance**.'
- In 1957, a mob and the governor blocked the **Little Rock Nine**.
- President **Eisenhower** sent federal troops to enforce the law.



The Montgomery Bus Boycott



- The 1955 murder of **Emmett Till** had already shocked the nation.
- When **Rosa Parks** was arrested, Montgomery's Black community boycotted the buses for a year.
- It launched **Martin Luther King Jr.** and the philosophy of **nonviolence**.

SECTION

Nonviolent Direct Action

Sit-ins & Freedom Rides



- In 1960, students staged **sit-ins** at segregated lunch counters, beginning in **Greensboro**.
- They formed **SNCC** to coordinate youth activism.
- **Freedom Rides** (1961) challenged segregation on interstate buses—and faced brutal violence.

Birmingham, 1963

- King targeted **Birmingham**—one of the most segregated cities in America.
- Police chief **Bull Connor** unleashed dogs and fire hoses on peaceful marchers—including children.
- Televised images shocked the nation and built support for federal action.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Movement Begins

1. **Brown v. Board** struck down school segregation, and **Little Rock** forced federal enforcement.
2. The **Montgomery Bus Boycott** launched **Dr. King** and the strategy of **nonviolence**.
3. **Sit-ins**, **Freedom Rides**, and **Birmingham** used nonviolent direct action to expose the brutality of Jim Crow.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Movement Begins

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how **Brown v. Board of Education** energized the civil rights movement.

COMPARISON

Compare the strategies of the **courts** and **nonviolent direct action**.

CONTEXTUALIZATION

How did **television** shape the nation's response to events like Birmingham?

Up next — **Class 56: The Movement Peaks** (the March on Washington & landmark laws)